FTK IMAGER FORENSICS LAB

Evidence Exploration, Keyword Search & Hash Review

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ITDF-1400-MY1 | Instructor: Mr. Valadez

Project overview

This portfolio presents a guided, hands-on introduction to Exterro FTK Imager. The coursework documents installation, exploration of the evidence interface, loading a provided practice evidence set, keyword searching, exporting files and hash lists, reviewing MD5 and SHA-1 values, and inspecting hexadecimal and ASCII data.

PROJECT TYPE	Digital forensics coursework / tool familiarization
PRIMARY TOOL	Exterro FTK Imager
EVIDENCE SOURCE	Provided chapter14.zip practice materials (extracted before use)
SCOPE	Training exercise; no real-world incident findings claimed

01 Installation and initial interface

I began by downloading the FTK Imager installer, following the setup wizard, and launching the application. I then identified the Evidence Tree and File List areas used to navigate loaded evidence and view associated file details.

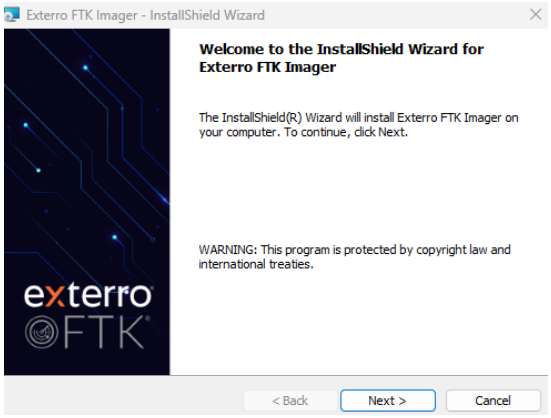


Figure 1. FTK Imager setup wizard shown during installation.

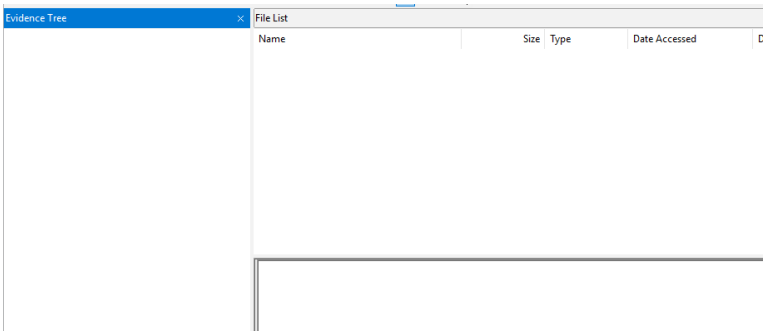


Figure 2. Initial FTK Imager workspace, including Evidence Tree and File List.

02 Loading practice evidence

The assignment used the provided **chapter14.zip** materials. After extracting the archive, I used the **File > Add Evidence Item** workflow to select the practice evidence for exploration. The interface offers additional options for disk imaging, verification, and export, but this assignment does not document creating or validating a forensic disk image.

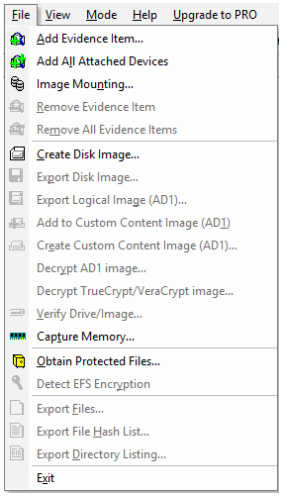


Figure 3. FTK Imager File menu with Add Evidence Item and other options.

03 Navigating data and searching

With the evidence loaded, I explored its structure and inspected file contents through FTK Imager's viewer. I also opened the Find dialog with **Ctrl+F** and reviewed text-search options. The source screenshot illustrates a search term entered as **test**; it does not establish that a matching artifact was found.

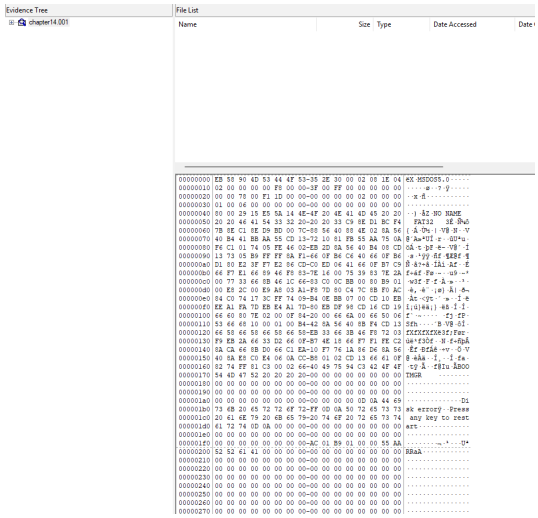


Figure 4. Loaded practice evidence and hex/ASCII viewing area.

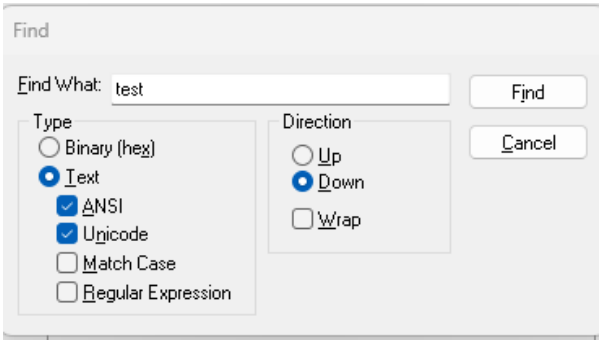


Figure 5. Find dialog configured for a text search.

04 File export and hash-list review

I navigated the Evidence Tree and used the context menu to explore **Export Files** and **Export File Hash List**. The assignment includes a view of exported hash-list content containing MD5 and SHA-1 fields. These values can support file identification and integrity comparisons, although no before-and-after verification comparison is documented here.

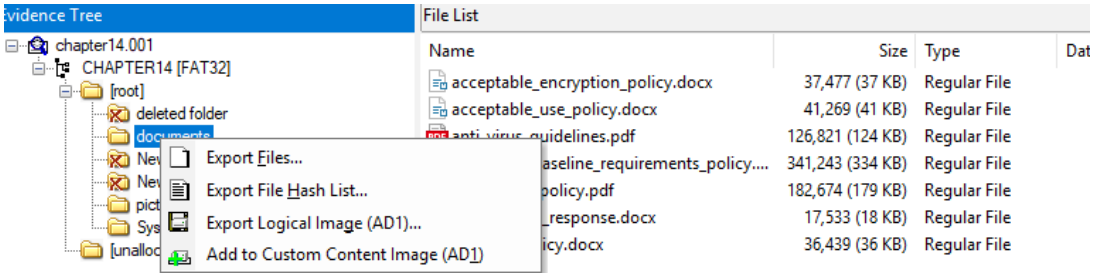


Figure 6. Evidence Tree context menu with export options.



Figure 7. Exported hash-list data viewed outside FTK Imager.

05 Hexadecimal and ASCII inspection

Finally, I explored the hexadecimal viewer alongside its ASCII interpretation. Viewing both representations helps explain how underlying bytes relate to readable text and recognizable file content. The lab demonstrates navigation and inspection, not the recovery of a deleted file or confirmation of malicious activity.

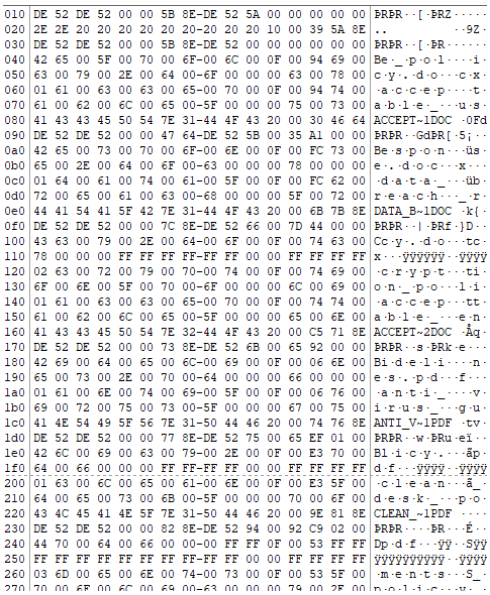


Figure 8. Hexadecimal bytes and corresponding ASCII representation.

Skills demonstrated

- Installed and navigated Exterro FTK Imager.
- Loaded a provided training evidence set and explored its directory structure.
- Used the Find dialog to explore text-search functionality.
- Explored file and hash-list export options and reviewed MD5/SHA-1 fields.
- Inspected raw hexadecimal data alongside ASCII text.

Reflection and next steps

This lab introduced core FTK Imager workflows and strengthened my familiarity with forensic evidence navigation, searching, exports, and byte-level inspection. A valuable next step would be to perform a controlled acquisition of a test image, record source and output hashes, verify the image, and document the results in a reproducible evidence log.

Attribution and limitations

Adapted from my September 2026 ITDF-1400-MY1 lab submission, *Exploring FTK Imager*. Screenshots are retained from the original coursework. This is an educational tool-exploration project; it does not assert completed forensic acquisition, hash verification, or a live investigation.